bleeding, injured people being put into cabs and carts to be taken to hospital. It was raining too, and the smell of burnt flesh and metal was all over the place. Light fumes of smoke could still be seen from the rain-cooled metal of the burnt train coach. The first class train compartment had been ripped apart and bodies and limbs were strewn around. My heart beat faster than ever as I saw locals trying to help the injured amidst cries of help. The train stood dead silent with the overhead wires snapped and lying on top of it. As I walked up the Mahim platform, I saw that a section of the roof on Platform 3 had a big hole in it, the point where the blast had occurred. Body parts of people were lying all over the rail tracks.

Walking a few minutes from there in the traffic, I reached Matunga, where there was another disfigured train coach, ripped open due to the impact of the bomb, and the same smell of flesh and metal, mixed with pouring rain. The mobile networks were all jammed. All I remember from the glimpses from Matunga overbridge was the mutilated coach No. 864-A. That evening, there had been seven blasts in seven trains in about 11 minutes, killing over 200 passengers in an abominable act of terrorism.

The sights at the Mahim and Matunga stations with bodies and mangled train coaches are etched in my memory for life. Even till six months later, I could identify the spot of the blast at Mahim station, as a tubelight was still missing from the station. The burnt 864-A coach at Matunga, too, lived on in my memory.

♦

August 2018. Twelve years down the line. I am travelling in coach 864-A. Yes. The same coach that I had seen at Matunga station. Of the seven blast-affected rail coaches, five had been restored within one year at a cost of ₹1–1.2 crore but were slowly phased out in these years. Two coaches had been immediately ‘condemned’, as they were beyond repair. I had been following them, writing about them for the next few years, but later forgot about them. But earlier that month, when I heard that 864-A, the only one among the restored, had lived on and had been shifted to a different passenger line, I could not hold myself back.

I waited for it for three hours, and there it was! They had not changed the number, and this coach was part of a twelve-car train on the Thane-Vashi section. I climbed the same first class coach for travel. I stood